



REFRAMING NEGATIVE THOUGHTS | EXERCISE 5

Individual or Group Exercise

This exercise aims to highlight the feelings that Negative and Positive thoughts evoke.

In this Exercise participants move between two chairs which represent Positive and Negative viewpoints. Every time they move they present either their Positive or Negative viewpoint. The exercise administrator asks situational questions and requests the respondents to imagine themselves thinking negatively and positively. In a group situation participants take it in turns.

As the respondents switch from positive to negative thoughts, they change position between the two chairs. At the end of the session, the respondents come up with their experiences of positive and negative thinking and evaluate which pattern of thought made them feel better.

Use the situational questions below to compose your own positive or negative thoughts OR use the example answers -it will still demonstrate to you how positive v negative thinking patterns make you feel.

1 Example ONE of situational question: your organisation announces that it will be undertaking restructuring, what is your reaction?

POSITIVE THOUGHTS	NEGATIVE THOUGHTS
Unnecessary processes and operations may be eliminated.	Redundancies
Objectives may shift from process-driven objectives to achieving business goals.	Uncertainty during the restructuring causing high levels of stress and potential conflict with colleagues.
Increased efficiency, morale and productivity.	Fear of having to learn new technology and processes.
Long-term stability and growth.	Increased workload especially if there are workforce reductions.
New challenges that enable professional learning and development.	Impact on customers including potential loss of clients/contracts.
Opportunities for promotion &/or pay rises.	There may be a better way of doing things.

Exercise continues on the next page...



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2 Example TWO of situational question: Another team member working on a project with you disagrees strongly with the approach you suggest, what is your reaction?

POSITIVE THOUGHTS	NEGATIVE THOUGHTS
It's good that your colleague has their own opinions and is proposing some alternative solutions.	They don't like me.
Since both of you are engaging in the process, the ultimate responsibility will be shared between the two of you.	They think I'm no good at my job.
Being able to explore a number of different options will result in a better overall solution for your organisation and the client.	They will tell my manager that I'm not up to the task.
Collaborating in this way builds a good working relationship with your colleague which will be useful for future projects.	The customer will lose confidence in me and ask for the other person in future.

3 Example THREE of situational question: my line manager often overloads me with work in the evenings and at weekends, saying that they can't rely on any other team members to get the job done. What Positive and Negative thoughts come from this situation?

POSITIVE THOUGHTS	NEGATIVE THOUGHTS
My manager thinks I am competent and produce good work.	My manager doesn't respect my boundaries and home-life.
My manager trusts me to complete important tasks in a short time-scale.	My manager knows that I am easier to persuade than other team members.
My manager knows that I am a loyal and committed employee.	My manager knows I will be worried about the possible consequences of refusing to work out of hours.
My manager sees me as their 'second in command'.	My manager thinks I don't have any friends or leisure activities and therefore can work at any time.
My manager sees that I have potential and they are providing me with a wide range of challenges in order to progress my career.	My manager ultimately does not care about my wellbeing.



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How to increase Positivity and Optimism - Best Practice



Avoid negative self-talk – after an event consider what you have learned and how you might apply that in the future rather than focusing on any negative aspects.



Challenge a negative thought – how accurate is it? Is it true to say that you 'never do anything right'?



Reframe the situation – look for ways to reframe an event in a more positive light.



Avoid jumping to conclusions: if a colleague appears distant or responds negatively towards you, rather than assuming it is something you did, consider what other outside influences may be impacting them.



Embrace challenges as opportunities for growth "I can't do this," becomes "I can't do this yet, but I'm learning."



Cultivate a growth mindset. Stimulating your brain with new skills/activities/learning can re-wire your brain, increase neural connections, positivity, and resilience.



Positive affirmations: "I can do this" "I've done this before and succeeded"



Re-direct your attention when re-living negative events/outcomes. Listen to music, walk, read a book.



Set realistic goals



Take time to savour and bank positive experiences into your long-term memory. Replay it several times in your memory and focus on how it made you feel.



Surround yourself with positive influences/people/support network: have lunch with positive colleagues and get their opinion on any ongoing challenges to get a different perspective.



Practice self-care: take care of your physical and mental wellbeing, including good nutrition, restorative sleep, and regular exercise.



Appreciate the small successes throughout the working day. Where you are involved in a major project, focus on the last few tasks you completed to give you a sense of achievement.



Cultivate positive thoughts, for example, rather than resenting time spent commuting, use it to learn a new skill or to review your ongoing tasks.



Make every situation a lesson learned: Review tasks or projects on completion: consider the challenges, what went well, and what you would do differently the next time to make the next project even more successful.



Use positive language in your workplace conversations to create a positive environment and make your team more optimistic about a project or deadline.



Express gratitude every day by reflecting on achievements, people, events, such as a successful presentation and make sure you thank people.



Find three positive aspects to every situation/challenge. For example, even though a team project is challenging positive aspects may be having the opportunity to work with the other team members or learn a new skill.



Participate in activities that reduce stress and boost mood such as socialising with friends, yoga, tai-chi, meditation, volunteering, physical challenges.



CBT (Cognitive Behavioural Therapy): identifies negative thoughts and challenges them with evidence.



Mindfulness & Meditation: Mindfulness involves being present in the moment and observing your thoughts without judgement and is a good way of breaking negative thought cycles.

Through the above strategies you can start to reshape your thought patterns and cultivate a more positive mindset to create a brain environment that's more positive and resilient.